The Aging Parent Care Planning Checklist

What to notice, talk about and ask while Mom is still managing at home.

Mom still does most things herself, and you've noticed a few small changes. Nothing has to happen this week. Check what you've looked at, talked about or written down. Anything unchecked is something to get to when there's a good moment, not a verdict about Mom.

Notice

- [ ] Her health as she describes it, and the diagnoses you know about, with who told you.
- [ ] Anything you've noticed about her memory, written as what you saw and when, not what you think it means.
- [ ] How she gets around, indoors and out: what she holds onto, how she gets up from a chair, and any falls during the past year. [2]
- [ ] What she does on her own in an ordinary week: bathing and dressing, meals, housework, shopping, bills and mail. [1]
- [ ] The medications she takes, and how she keeps track of them. [2]
- [ ] Whether she drives, where and when, and how she gets around otherwise.
- [ ] Who helps her now, with what and how often, including the small things nobody counts as help.
- [ ] What has changed during the past year, with a rough date beside each change.

Talk about with Mom

- [ ] Where she'd prefer to live and receive care if she ever needed more help, and how important staying at home is to her.
- [ ] What she'd expect from family, and what each of you is able to offer.
- [ ] Who she wants involved in decisions, and what matters most to her, written down in her own words.

Ask

- [ ] Anything about the house you'd like someone to look at, such as the lighting, the stair rails or the bathroom, written as a question. [2]
- [ ] The kinds of care you've heard named (home care, adult day programs, assisted living, memory care, skilled nursing), and your questions about each, including what it costs.
- [ ] Which changes her doctor would want to hear about, and which would be a reason to look at all of this again.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you notice, talk and ask. It doesn't say what a change means, whether Mom needs more help, or what kind. That's for the people who know her health and her situation. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've looked, talked and listed your questions. The care interview walks you through Mom's situation area by area so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The item marked 1 follows the everyday activities LongTermCare.gov lists. Items marked 2 follow its page on avoiding a fall, which suggests noticing how a person walks, asking about medications and looking over the home. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Avoiding a Fall